

Sexuality and Gender Minority Families: Parenting Outside the Binary

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Sexual orientation and gender identity are essential parts of the human experience. The concerns against sexual minority parenting revolve around issues of conventional family values, going on to create highly controversial debates around the parenting abilities of LGBTQ+ parents concerning child adjustment, gender development, and potential gender dysmorphia or sexualities. Addressing the unique challenges that SGM parents and their children face, the American Psychology Association (APA) aims to create a more knowledgeable and safer world for those raising families outside the traditional norms (American Psychology Association, 2020, p. 4).

Sexual minority (SM) individuals identify with non-dominant sexual identities, while gender minority (GM) individuals identify with non-dominant gender identities. Estimates of the population of gender minority adults are around 0.3%-0.5% of the general U.S. population, although the likelihood of identifying as transgender is higher for younger generations. GM individuals were more likely to be people of color. A majority of sexual minority adults are currently parents or would like to be, with six million children in the United States having a lesbian, gay, or bisexual parent. Same-sex couples are increasingly raising children; this is especially true for married same-sex couples. Rates are significantly higher among people of color. However, research has not been sufficient to alleviate the fears of gender traditionalists (American Psychology Association, 2020, p. 1).

Recent studies have explored a variety of aspects, including sexual orientation, parenthood, race, and more. Since the 1970s, a body of research has shown that there are no

significant differences in sexual minorities' parenting styles compared with heterosexual adults. With this, children raised by sexual minority parents indicate no differences in development compared to other children concerning their performance in schools, social relations, and emotional development. Interestingly, studies have further revealed that children raised by sexual minority parents often demonstrate more significant critical thinking and flexibility regarding gender-based play (Sumontha et al., 2017).

There is a noticeable detriment to individuals and families within the sexual minority, mainly racial/ethnic discrimination or economic hardship. Both children and parents in sexual minority families may face victimization due to their familial structure, thereby impacting child adjustment. Despite these adversities, research indicates that children from sexual minority families have vital resilience factors and think positively of their familial structure (American Psychology Association, 2020, p. 2).

Contrary to popular belief, research emphasizes that family processes, such as parenting quality, bear a more significant influence on child outcomes than family structure concerning parental sexual orientation. This finding demonstrates that LGBTQ+ adults are as competent at parenting as their heterosexual counterparts. External factors, such as community and legal environments, also significantly influence the welfare of individuals within sexual minority parent families (American Psychology Association, 2020, p. 2).

Being a part of the gender minority is accompanied by additional challenges resulting from the lack of legal protection in matters of parenthood, job security, housing, and school due to the stigma against their gender identity. These can have unfavorable consequences on well-being and family life. Feeling the more notable punch of stigma, discrimination, and lack of support than others are gender minority individuals, especially those who are people of color,

which has negative healthcare experiences and cultural competence gaps (American Psychology Association, 2020, p. 3).

For people of color, however, legal, social, systemic, and structural discrimination comes on top of these challenges. With so many barriers, there is no difference in the capacity for child-rearing for gender minority individuals compared to cisgender individuals. Despite society's obstacles, there is no negative impact of parental gender identity on family life and child welfare indicators during a child's formative years. In order to assist LGBTQ+ parents, helping shift the narrative that only nuclear families are successful can foster more acceptance and community for those who need it(American Psychology Association, 2020, p. 4).

References

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